



# The Day the Dam Broke

By

James Thurber



## About the Writer



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|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Name</b>            | James Groves Thurber                                |
| <b>Born &amp; died</b> | December 8, 1894 – November 2, 1961                 |
| <b>Place of birth</b>  | Columbus, Ohio, USA                                 |
| <b>Profession</b>      | Cartoonist, Journalist and Humorist                 |
| <b>Literary period</b> | Modernism                                           |
| <b>Notable works</b>   | My Life and Hard Time, The 13 Clocks and Many Moons |

## The Essay

|                        |                                                                |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Type of work</b>    | A Humorous Narrative Essay Recalling the actual incident       |
| <b>Written</b>         | 1933                                                           |
| <b>Setting (Place)</b> | Columbus, Ohio, USA                                            |
| <b>Main Theme(s)</b>   | Mob Mentality, Impact of rumors, Adversity tests our character |

## Short Question Answer

Q1- How did the panic start on High Street in “The Day the Dam Broke”?

**Ans-** On 12 March in 1913, High Street was busy as usual with its daily activities. Suddenly someone began to run. James Thurber estimates that perhaps the person ran because he was getting late for an appointment to meet his wife. Immediately, someone else began to run and within ten minutes time, everybody on that street was running. This sudden chaotic situation created a lot of panic. The running mob mumbled something that transformed into a dreadful word ‘dam’ and then ‘the dam has broke!’ Go east, go east’. Interestingly, no one could be held responsible for this disorder.

Q2 – In what way does the text illustrate the theme of the mob mentality?

**Ans-** Mob mentality appears when a mistaken warning about a dam breaking makes the whole town flee, copying others without checking if it’s true.

James Thurber humorously recounts how a harmless misunderstanding spiraled into mass panic. A false shout about a dam breaking sent a few people running, which quickly encouraged others to do the same. Without pausing to question the situation, nearly everyone joined the rush, believing danger was real because the crowd acted afraid. Reason gave way to imitation, and fear became contagious. This scene captures the essence of mob mentality—people abandoning independent thinking to follow the group—turning an ordinary day into a chaotic but comically exaggerated flight for safety.

Q3 – How did different individuals and groups react to this news?

**Ans-** In *The Day the Dam Broke*, the false alarm about the dam bursting set off a range of reactions. Many citizens ran through the streets, convinced the flood was coming. Parents grabbed children, neighbors shouted warnings, and whole families joined the stampede. Some, like the narrator's grandfather, calmly walked along, puzzled by the rush. Others hesitated at first but eventually followed the crowd, afraid of being left behind. This mix of blind panic, urgent concern, and quiet confusion reflects how individuals and groups respond differently when swept up in sudden, unexpected fear.

Q4 – How did the panic end so abruptly and why nobody talked about it for the long time?

**Ans-** The chaos stopped as quickly as it began. Some runners noticed calm individuals standing around or heard voices saying the dam had not broken. The truth spread rapidly, and people slowed down, returning to their normal activities. However, the event became an unspoken memory for years. Those involved were too embarrassed to admit they had fled in fear without confirming the danger. The sudden switch from mass hysteria to ordinary life—and the shared reluctance to revisit the foolishness—added to the humor in Thurber's account.

Q5 – How long did the panic last and how was the order restored?

OR

How was the order restored in the Columbus city in 1913?

**Ans-** In Columbus, Ohio in 1913, a rumor caused great noise *and panic* among the public. The panic lasted for about two hours. At last, the militiamen came out of the roads and announced that the dam had not broken and the news was only a rumor. At first, the announcement added to confusion and increased panic. For the crowd took it a 'The dam has **now** broken!' But the repeated announcements removed this misunderstanding. All the people took a sigh of relief at the normalcy of the situation. They returned to their homes safe but embarrassed.

Q6 – How does the author describe the business and behavior of people in Columbus the next day of the panic?

**Ans-** James Thurber humorously notes that the day after the panic, Columbus returned to its normal pace. Shops opened, people went to work, and daily routines continued as though the wild rout had never occurred. There were no public discussions or mentions of the incident, as everyone seemed willing to avoid the embarrassment of admitting they had run in fear over a false alarm. This quiet return to normalcy reflects that the panic-stricken people tried to forget their moment of collective foolishness.

Q7 – Describe the response of the law enforcement, fire-fighters, and military personnel during the panic. How did their actions demonstrate civic duty?

**Ans-** The false alarm triggered action not only from townspeople but also from law enforcement, fire-fighters, and military personnel. Seeing the crowd's fear, they stepped in to assist, directing people away

from the danger and helping maintain some order amid the confusion. Even though the threat was imaginary, their willingness to act quickly reflected strong civic responsibility. By putting themselves in the midst of the chaos to safeguard others, they demonstrated the commitment of public service workers to respond to emergencies for the community's safety.

**Q8 –** Amidst the chaos and confusion, how did the author's mother / family uphold their civic responsibilities during the incident?

**Ans-** Amidst the widespread chaos, it was Thurber's mother who stood out with her composure and good judgment. While nearly everyone else in the town ran in fear, she neither panicked nor acted hastily. Instead, she remained steady, choosing not to rush into the streets or fuel the hysteria. Her refusal to follow the crowd was a quiet form of civic responsibility, by not adding to the confusion, she helped reduce the spread of needless fear, setting an example of sensibility in a moment of collective madness.

**Q9 –** How did the panic start in the movie theatre / cinema on the High Street?

**Ans-** According to the writer's aunt, Edith Taylor, all was normal during the movie show. The trouble started when the audience heard the increasing tramp of the mob outside the theatre. The first reaction inside the theatre came from the elderly man sitting near her. He mumbled something, got out of his seat and walked out briskly through the aisle. This startled the other people and they too left their seats to rush out the theatre. To make matters worse, an old lady shouted the word 'Fire' and added more fear to the situation that resulted in a complete evacuation of the theatre.

**Q10 –** How did Thurber's mother cope with the situation?

**Ans-** Thurber's mother tried to cope with the situation quite wisely. When the panic spread all over, She thought of a way to save her life along with her family. She kept her nerves under control. Before fleeing the house, she put out all the fires, took a dozen eggs and two loaves of bread. Her plan was to take refuge somewhere in the top of Memorial Hall which was two blocks away. But the mob failed her plan when it pulled her along with it.

**Q11 -** What caused the lieutenant colonel of infantry to lead the fleeing company of three hundred persons?

**Ans-** The lieutenant colonel was drowsing on a porch when a little girl crying 'Go east' ran past him. He got up instantly, jumped of the porch and went to running and shouting 'Go east!' When asked by someone why he was running and shouting thus, he stopped and asked the girl the same question. When she told him that the dam had broken, the colonel took the girl in his arms and went on running and creaming 'Go east! Go east! Go east!'. This irresponsible behavior of the colonel brought about three hundred out of their living rooms, shops, garages, backyards and basements all led by him.

**Q12-** Why did the dr. Mallory think that the flood water was shouting to engulf him?

OR

Describe the humorous incident of Dr. Mallory in 'The Day the Dam Broke'.

**Ans-** Dr, Mallory was also among those who were running in panic for his life during the dame breaking incident. There was a boy behind him on a roller skate and he mistook the swishing of skates for the sound of rushing water. Impulsively, he shouted. 'It got us. He stood and jogged until the boy passed him with whizzing sound. It was only then that he realized his mistake. In spite of the fact that there was no water behind, he still began to jog on the street again.

**Meanings and synonyms of the words/phrases extracted from the essay “The Day the Dam Broke”:**

1. **Aisle** – A passage between rows of seats, shelves, or other structures.  
*Synonyms:* corridor, walkway, passage, lane
2. **Assuage** – To make an unpleasant feeling less intense.  
*Synonyms:* relieve, ease, soothe, alleviate
3. **Boast** – To talk with pride about something.  
*Synonyms:* brag, show off, flaunt, vaunt
4. **Bawl** – To cry or shout loudly.  
*Synonyms:* yell, wail, howl, sob
5. **Bellow** – To shout loudly in a deep voice.  
*Synonyms:* roar, boom, holler, thunder
6. **Billow** – To swell or surge outward.  
*Synonyms:* surge, swell, balloon, puff up
7. **Bluff** – To deceive or mislead someone into believing you will do something.  
*Synonyms:* deceive, pretend, feign, mislead
8. **Bound off** – To leap or jump quickly away.  
*Synonyms:* spring off, leap away, jump off, skip away
9. **Brandish** – To wave something (often a weapon) as a threat or in excitement.  
*Synonyms:* flourish, wield, swing, shake
10. **Calamity** – A great disaster or misfortune.  
*Synonyms:* catastrophe, tragedy, disaster, adversity
11. **Canyon** – A deep gorge between cliffs.  
*Synonyms:* ravine, gorge, valley, chasm
12. **Cavalry** – Soldiers on horseback or, in modern armies, armored troops.  
*Synonyms:* horse soldiers, mounted troops, dragoons
13. **Clam** – A type of a silent person.  
*Synonyms:* introvert, silent person
14. **Clarion** – Loud and clear (often referring to a call or sound).  
*Synonyms:* resounding, clear, piercing, ringing
15. **Coherent** – Logical and consistent.  
*Synonyms:* logical, rational, cohesive, orderly

16. **Conviction** – A firmly held belief or a formal declaration of guilt.  
*Synonyms:* belief, opinion, persuasion; sentence, judgment
17. **Crank** – A bad-tempered or eccentric person.  
*Synonyms:* grouch, oddball, grumbler, eccentric
18. **Cynical** – Believing people are motivated by self-interest; distrustful of sincerity.  
*Synonyms:* distrustful, skeptical, pessimistic, suspicious
19. **Demoralize** – To weaken someone's confidence or spirit.  
*Synonyms:* discourage, dishearten, dispirit, undermine
20. **Despair** – Loss of hope.  
*Synonyms:* hopelessness, anguish, misery, discouragement
21. **Desperado** – A bold, reckless criminal or outlaw.  
*Synonyms:* outlaw, bandit, villain, ruffian
22. **Desperation** – A state of hopelessness leading to rash behavior.  
*Synonyms:* hopelessness, anguish, despair, recklessness
23. **Die down** – To become weaker or quieter.  
*Synonyms:* subside, diminish, lessen, fade
24. **Dispel** – To drive away or cause to vanish.  
*Synonyms:* banish, eliminate, dismiss, scatter
25. **Drowse** – To be half-asleep.  
*Synonyms:* doze, nap, snooze, slumber lightly
26. **Exhort** – To strongly urge or encourage.  
*Synonyms:* urge, encourage, admonish, press
27. **Froth** – Bubbles formed on a liquid.  
*Synonyms:* foam, bubbles, suds, lather
28. **Galley** – A kitchen on a ship or aircraft; also, a type of long, narrow ship.  
*Synonyms:* ship's kitchen, vessel, boat, trireme
29. **Gasp** – To inhale suddenly in surprise or pain.  
*Synonyms:* pant, inhale sharply, wheeze, gulp
30. **Grim** – Harsh, forbidding, or without hope.  
*Synonyms:* stern, severe, bleak, harsh
31. **Grotesque** – Comically or repulsively ugly or distorted.  
*Synonyms:* distorted, monstrous, absurd, bizarre
32. **Harness** – To control and make use of (a resource).  
*Synonyms:* utilize, employ, control, exploit

33. **Headwater** – The source of a river.  
*Synonyms:* source, origin, spring, fountainhead
34. **Impede** – To delay or block progress.  
*Synonyms:* obstruct, hinder, block, slow down
35. **Inert** – Lacking movement or energy.  
*Synonyms:* motionless, inactive, lifeless, still
36. **Infantry** – Soldiers who fight on foot.  
*Synonyms:* foot soldiers, ground troops, grunts
37. **Perilous** – Full of danger.  
*Synonyms:* dangerous, risky, hazardous, unsafe
38. **Persistent** – Continuing firmly despite obstacles.  
*Synonyms:* determined, stubborn, steadfast, enduring
39. **Phenomenon** – A remarkable event or fact.  
*Synonyms:* occurrence, event, happening, marvel
40. **Placid** – Calm and peaceful.  
*Synonyms:* serene, tranquil, quiet, gentle
41. **Portly** – Stout or overweight in a dignified way.  
*Synonyms:* stout, chubby, corpulent, heavyset
42. **Puff** – A short burst of air or smoke.  
*Synonyms:* gust, breath, blast, wisp
43. **Ragtag and Bobtail** – Common people.  
*Synonyms:* riffraff, mob
44. **Rout** – A disorderly retreat of defeated troops.  
*Synonyms:* retreat, flight, collapse, defeat
45. **Sabre** – A curved sword.  
*Synonyms:* sword, blade, cutlass, scimitar
46. **Seething** – Filled with intense but unexpressed anger.  
*Synonyms:* boiling, fuming, raging, smoldering
47. **Sheepish** – Showing embarrassment or shame.  
*Synonyms:* embarrassed, awkward, bashful, shy
48. **Shove** – To push roughly.  
*Synonyms:* push, thrust, propel, jostle
49. **Slink** – To move quietly, trying not to be noticed.  
*Synonyms:* creep, sneak, tiptoe, skulk

50. **Splendour** – Magnificent and splendid appearance.  
*Synonyms:* grandeur, magnificence, glory, brilliance
51. **Sprawl** – To sit or lie with limbs spread awkwardly.  
*Synonyms:* lounge, spread out, recline, loll
52. **Staid** – Serious, respectable, and unadventurous.  
*Synonyms:* sedate, proper, sober, formal
53. **Stampede** – A sudden rush of animals or people.  
*Synonyms:* rush, charge, bolt, surge
54. **Startle** – To surprise or frighten suddenly.  
*Synonyms:* shock, alarm, frighten, jolt
55. **Stenographer** – A person skilled in shorthand writing.  
*Synonyms:* typist, secretary, court reporter
56. **Straggle** – To move slowly or irregularly, falling behind.  
*Synonyms:* lag, trail, dawdle, drift
57. **Stun** – To shock or surprise greatly.  
*Synonyms:* astonish, amaze, daze, bewilder
58. **Surge** – A sudden powerful forward movement.  
*Synonyms:* rush, wave, swell, flow
59. **Swirl** – To move in a twisting pattern.  
*Synonyms:* whirl, twist, spiral, eddy
60. **Tangle** – To twist together into a confused mass.  
*Synonyms:* entwine, knot, snarl, entangle
61. **Throng** – A large, densely packed crowd.  
*Synonyms:* crowd, mob, horde, multitude
62. **Torn** – Pulled apart or divided; unable to decide.  
*Synonyms:* ripped, split, divided, conflicted
63. **Tramp** – To walk heavily or noisily.  
*Synonyms:* stomp, march, tread, hike
64. **Trickle** – To flow slowly in small quantities.  
*Synonyms:* drip, dribble, seep, ooze
65. **Trot** – To run at a moderate pace (often for horses).  
*Synonyms:* jog, run, pace, hurry
66. **Turmoil** – A state of great disturbance or confusion.  
*Synonyms:* chaos, disorder, commotion, upheaval

67. **Vengeful** – Wanting revenge.

*Synonyms:* revengeful, vindictive, spiteful, retaliatory

68. **Veteran** – An experienced person; also an ex-member of the armed forces.

*Synonyms:* expert, old hand, ex-soldier, seasoned professional

69. **Waddle** – To walk with short steps, swaying from side to side.

*Synonyms:* toddle, sway, shamble, hobble

70. **Wheedle** – To persuade using flattery.

*Synonyms:* coax, cajole, sweet-talk, entice

**15 multiple-choice questions (MCQs) from the essay “*The Day the Dam Broke*” by James Thurber.**

1. What sparked the panic in Columbus in *The Day the Dam Broke*?

- A) A dam actually breaking
- B) A false alarm about a dam breaking
- C) A flood from heavy rain
- D) A news report of a nearby disaster

2. How did most townspeople react to the rumor?

- A) They investigated quietly
- B) They gathered at the dam site
- C) They ran through the streets in fear
- D) They stayed indoors and waited

3. Which family member of Thurber showed calmness during the panic?

- A) His father
- B) His mother
- C) His grandfather
- D) His brother

4. What quality did Thurber’s mother display during the incident?

- A) Curiosity
- B) Anger
- C) Composure
- D) Indifference

5. How long did the panic last before the truth was known?

- A) 30 minutes
- B) One hour
- C) Two hours
- D) Half a day

- 6.** How did people realize the dam had not broken?
- A) They saw no water coming
  - B) A town official made an announcement
  - C) The radio gave an update
  - D) A fireman blew a whistle
- 7.** What did many people do simply because they saw others running?
- A) Joined the rush without questioning
  - B) Stopped to watch
  - C) Took photographs
  - D) Called for help
- 8.** How does the essay portray the crowd's behavior?
- A) As well-organized
  - B) As humorous and exaggerated
  - C) As heroic
  - D) As disciplined
- 9.** What happened the day after the panic?
- A) People laughed about it openly
  - B) Life returned to normal without mention of the event
  - C) A town meeting was held
  - D) Police made arrests for causing panic
- 10.** Which group also joined in helping during the incident?
- A) Teachers
  - B) Fire-fighters and police
  - C) Shopkeepers
  - D) School children
- 11.** What was one cause of the rumor spreading so quickly?
- A) A loud explosion
  - B) People copying others without verifying
  - C) The sound of rushing water
  - D) A church bell ringing
- 12.** How is the theme of mob mentality shown in the essay?
- A) Through people acting together with reason
  - B) Through group decision-making
  - C) Through people following the crowd without thinking
  - D) Through planned evacuation drills
- 13.** What tone does Thurber use to describe the event?
- A) Serious and tragic
  - B) Humorous and lighthearted

- C) Angry and bitter
- D) Calm and factual

**14.** Why did nobody speak of the incident for a long time?

- A) They forgot about it quickly
- B) They were embarrassed by their actions
- C) They were ordered to keep silent
- D) They feared the dam might still break

**15.** What larger idea about human behavior does the story suggest?

- A) People act independently in crises
- B) Fear spreads quickly in groups
- C) Truth always travels faster than lies
- D) Crowds rarely make mistakes

**Answer key with justifications:**

**1. B – A false alarm about a dam breaking**

*Justification:* The central incident in the essay is a mistaken belief that a dam had burst, leading to mass panic, though no actual flooding occurred.

**2. C – They ran through the streets in fear**

*Justification:* The majority of townspeople fled through the streets without verifying the truth, driven by fear of an imagined flood.

**3. B – His mother**

*Justification:* Thurber highlights his mother as the only family member mentioned who remained composed and did not join the panic.

**4. C – Composure**

*Justification:* She stayed calm and did not allow herself to be swept up in the hysteria, showing wisdom and self-control.

**5. C – Two hours**

*Justification:* The essay mentions the panic lasted about two hours before people realized there was no danger.

**6. A – They saw no water coming**

*Justification:* Many noticed the absence of any signs of flooding, and word spread that the dam was intact.

**7. A – Joined the rush without questioning**

*Justification:* The humor of the story comes from people running simply because they saw others running, without knowing why.

**8. B – As humorous and exaggerated**

*Justification:* Thurber uses a light, comical tone to describe the chaotic overreaction of the crowd.

**9. B – Life returned to normal without mention of the event**

*Justification:* The next day, Columbus functioned as usual, and people avoided talking about the incident out of embarrassment.

**10. B – Fire-fighters and police**

*Justification:* Public service workers joined the effort, guiding people and helping maintain order, even though the danger was false.

**11. B – People copying others without verifying**

*Justification:* The rumor spread through imitation, as people ran because others were running, showing mob mentality.

**12. C – Through people following the crowd without thinking**

*Justification:* Mob mentality is portrayed when fear spreads rapidly, and individuals act without personal judgment.

**13. B – Humorous and lighthearted**

*Justification:* The essay treats the incident with playful exaggeration, highlighting its absurdity rather than tragedy.

**14. B – They were embarrassed by their actions**

*Justification:* People avoided speaking of the event for years to escape the shame of having panicked for no reason.

**15. B – Fear spreads quickly in groups**

*Justification:* The broader message of the story is how quickly fear can infect a crowd, leading to irrational mass behavior.

